THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Beginner

Read it like a storybook: one step on each page, a big picture, a few words, and one thing to try at the piano. The last room trains your ears.

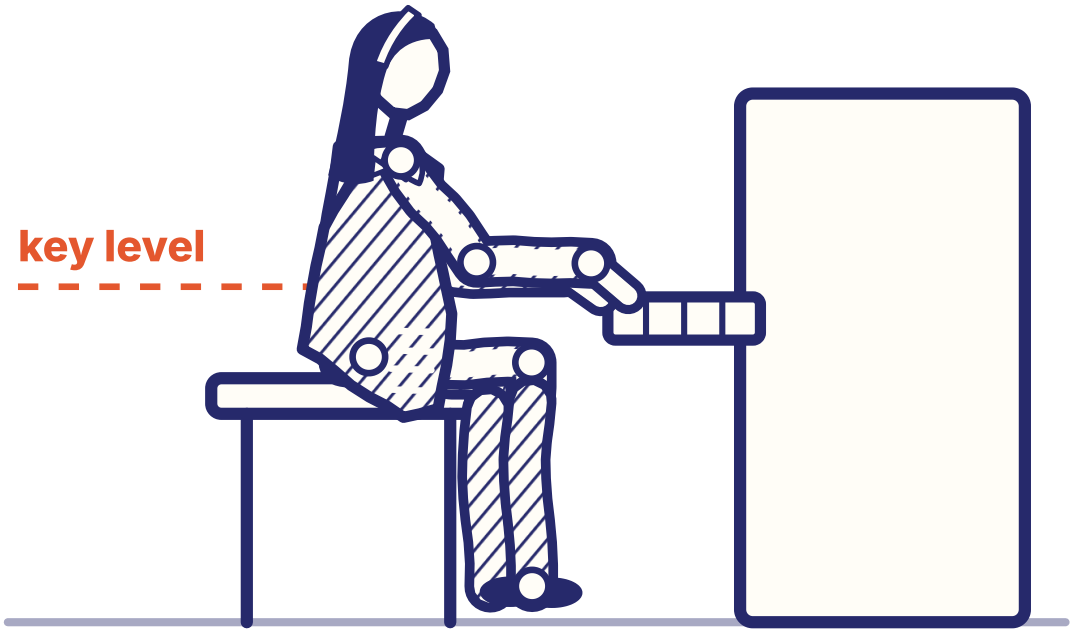
THE ROOMS

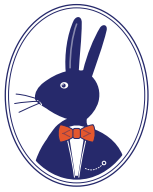
1 · Sitting and hands
2 · The keyboard
3 · Finger numbers
4 · The staff and the clefs
5 · The beat
6 · Notes: crotchet and minim
7 · Notes: dotted minim and semibreve
8 · Loud and soft
9 · Ear training

ROOM 1 · STEP 1 OF 3

Sitting and hands

SCAN TO LISTEN





Sit tall on the front half of the stool, with both **feet flat** on the floor.

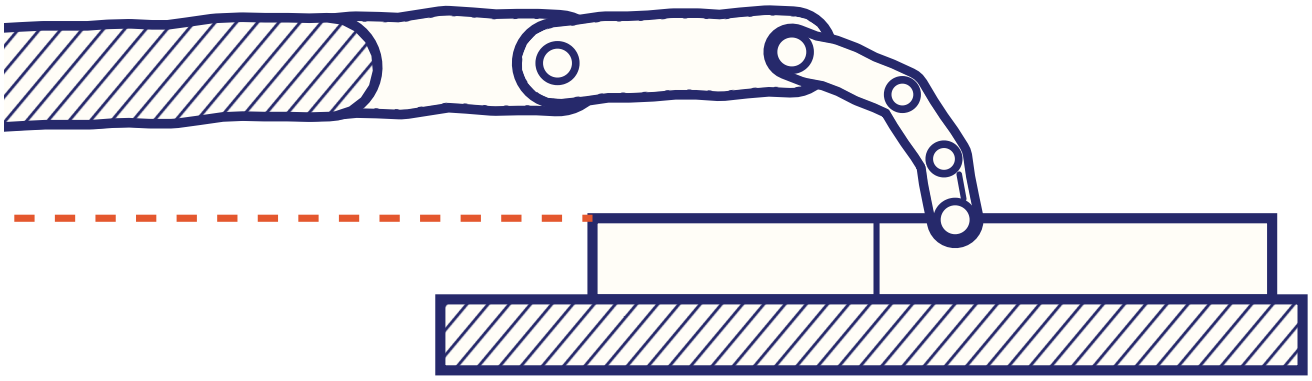
Your arms float out in front, **level with the keys**, like a table top.

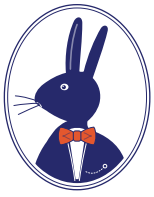
Try it

1 Sit down. Lift your shoulders up to your ears, then let them drop.

ROOM 1 · STEP 2 OF 3

Sitting and hands





Hold a small ball in your hand. That **round shape** is your playing hand.

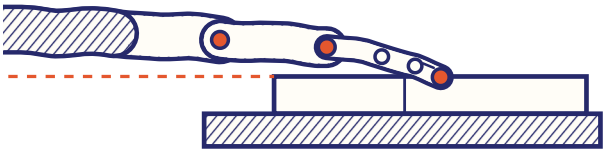
Your knuckles stand up like a **bridge**, and you play on your **fingertips**.

Try it at the piano

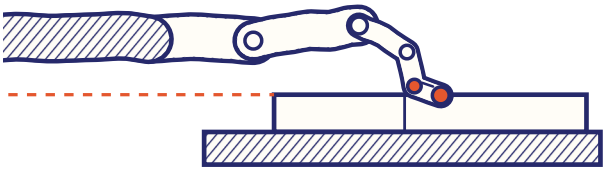
1. Hold a ball or an orange. Put your hand on the keys without changing its shape.

ROOM 1 · STEP 3 OF 3

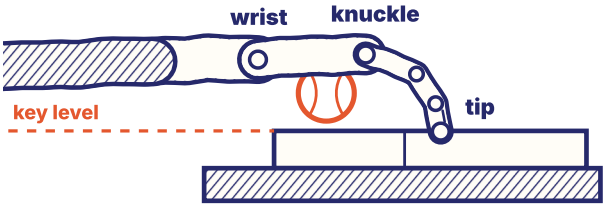
Sitting and hands



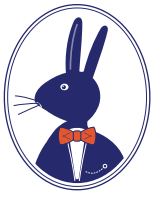
× flat



× fallen in



✓ round



A **flat** hand is fast asleep. A bridge that has **fallen in** cannot carry anything.

The **round** hand can play all day.

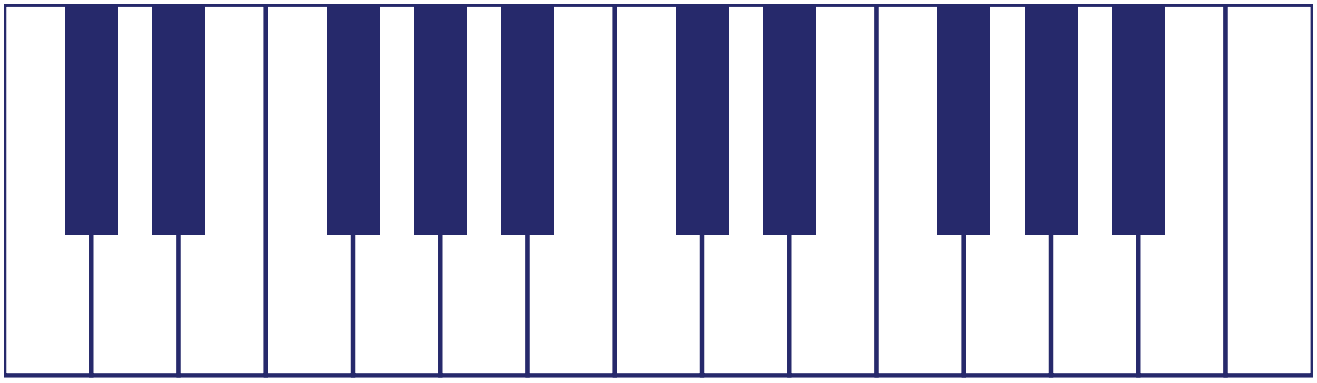
Try it

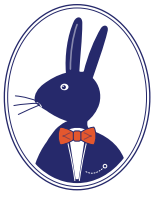
1 Make the flat hand, then the fallen bridge, then the round hand. Feel the difference.

ROOM 2 · STEP 1 OF 3

The keyboard

SCAN TO LISTEN





Look at the black keys. They come in **twos** and **threes**, again and again, all the way along.

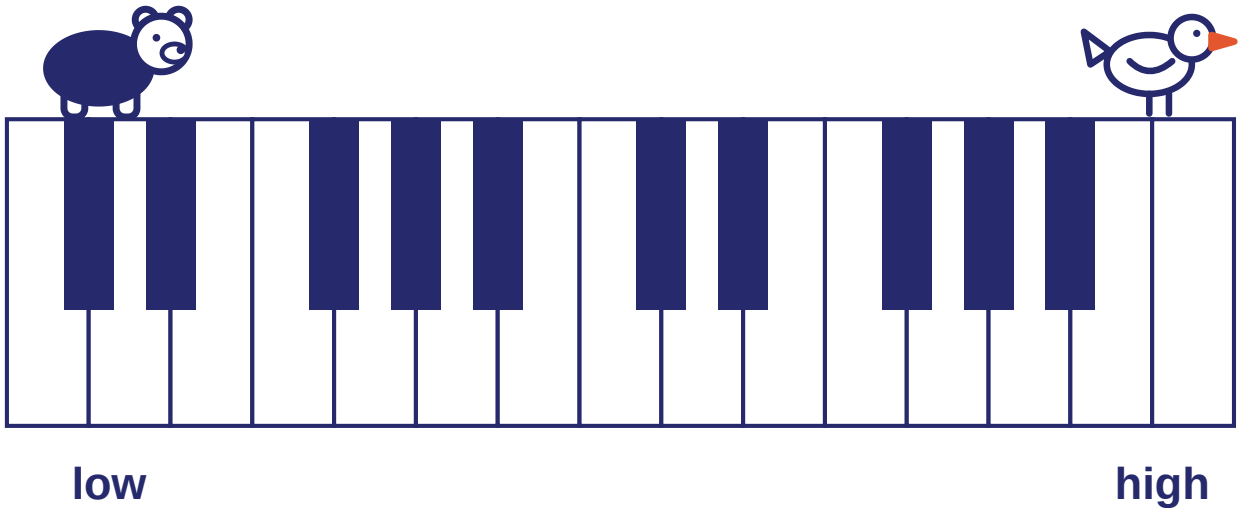
Find the pattern once and you can never get lost.

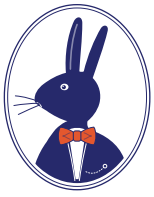
Try it at the piano

1 Touch every group of two black keys, from the left end to the right end. Then every group of three.

ROOM 2 · STEP 2 OF 3

The keyboard





Left is low, like a big grumpy bear. **Right is high**, like a little bird.

Go to the right and every key sounds a little higher.

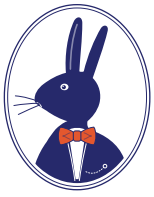
Try it at the piano

1. Play the lowest key you can reach, then the highest. Bear, then bird. ○

ROOM 2 · STEP 3 OF 3

The keyboard





Every white key has a letter. Beside the **two** black keys live **C, D, E**. Beside the **three** live **F, G, A, B**.

After B comes C again: seven letters, round and round.

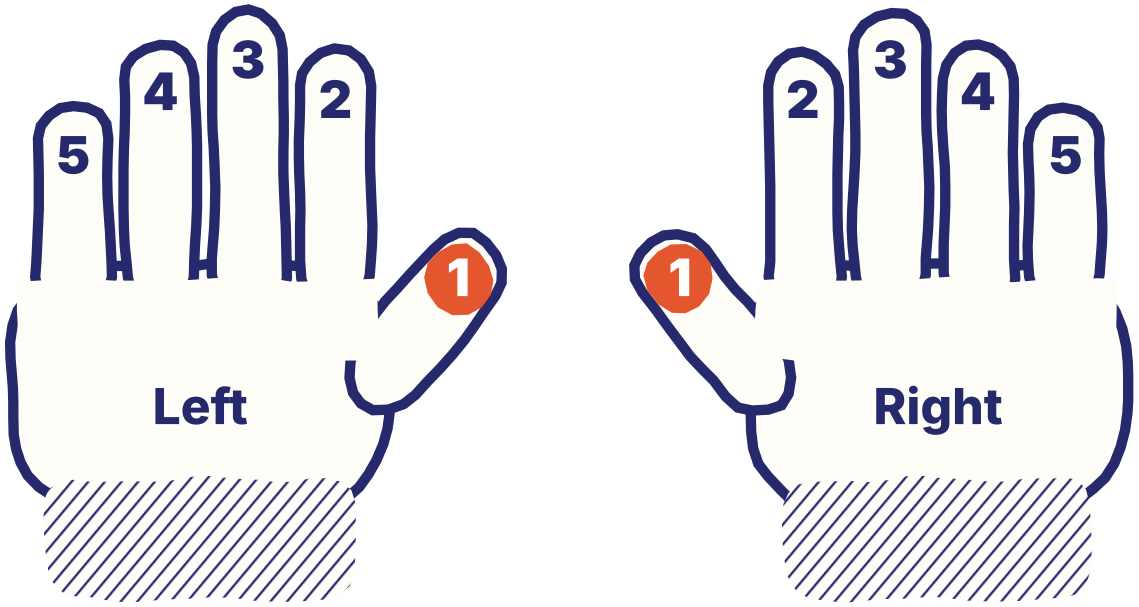
Try it at the piano

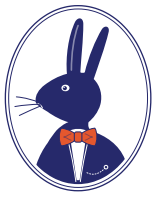
1. Find a group of two black keys. Play the three white keys around it and say C, D, E.

ROOM 3 · STEP 1 OF 2

Finger numbers

SCAN TO LISTEN





Every finger has a **number**. The **thumb is 1**, then 2, 3, 4, and the little finger is **5**.

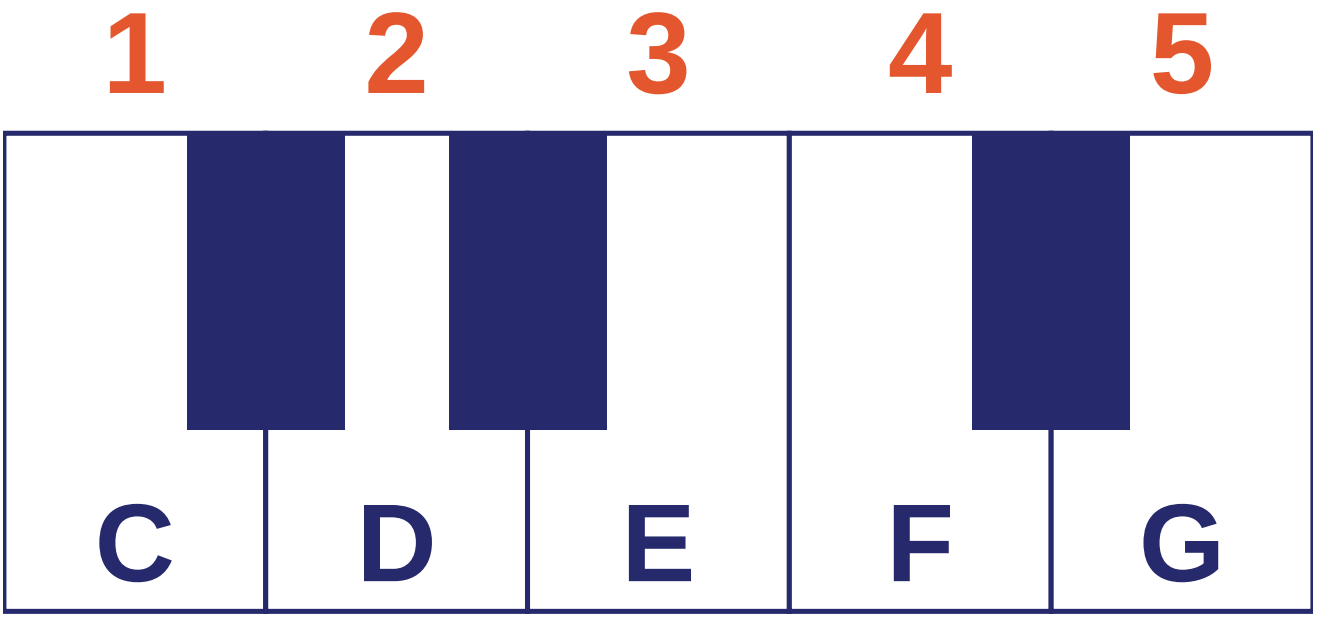
It is the same in both hands: thumbs are always 1.

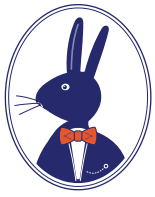
Try it

1. Hold up both hands. Wiggle finger 1, then 2, 3, 4, 5, saying the numbers.

ROOM 3 · STEP 2 OF 2

Finger numbers





Find any **C**: the white key just left of two black keys. Put your right thumb on it. Now **C D E F G** are fingers **1 2 3 4 5**.

In the left hand the little finger starts: C D E F G are **5 4 3 2 1**.

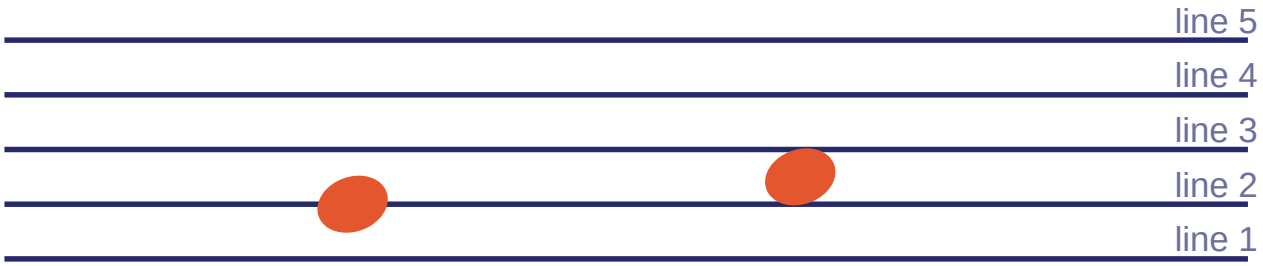
Try it at the piano

1 Right thumb on C. Play C D E F G and back, saying the finger numbers. Then the left hand, starting with finger 5.

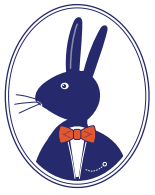
ROOM 4 · STEP 1 OF 2

The staff and the clefs

SCAN TO LISTEN



on a line **in a space**



Music is written on **five lines**, called the **staff**.

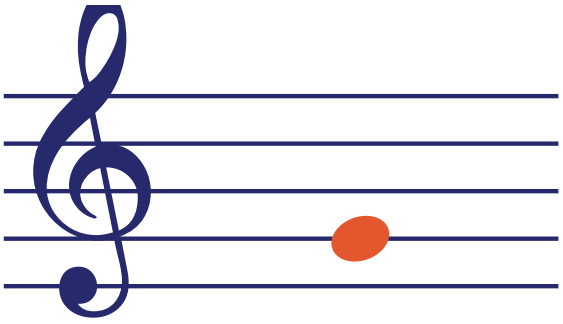
A note can sit **on a line**. Or it can sit **in a space**. Higher up means higher on the piano.

Try it

1 Count the lines from the bottom: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5. Then count the four spaces.

ROOM 4 · STEP 2 OF 2

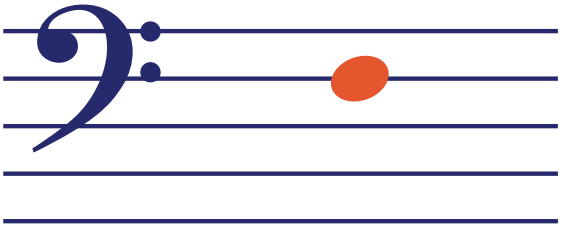
The staff and the clefs



G

Treble clef

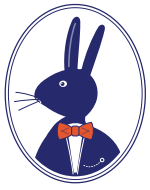
the Queen · her curl holds the G line



F

Bass clef

the King · his dots hug the F line



A **clef** at the start says which notes the lines stand for.

The **treble clef** is the Queen of the high notes: her curl wraps round the line for **G**. The **bass clef** is the King of the low notes: his two dots hug the line for **F**.

Try it at the piano

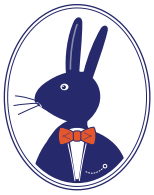
1. Play any high key with your right hand: the Queen's side. Then any low key with your left: the King's side.

ROOM 5 · STEP 1 OF 2

The beat

SCAN TO LISTEN





Music has a steady **beat**, like a heartbeat. It never speeds up and never stops.

We count the beats: 1, 2, 3, 4, and round again.

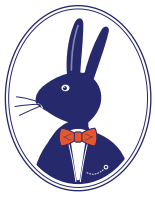
Try it

1. Put a hand on your heart. Tap that steady beat on your knee and count 1 2 3 4.

ROOM 5 · STEP 2 OF 2

The beat





Bar lines put the beats into groups called **bars**.
Beat 1 of every bar is the strongest.

Sometimes a beat is **silent**. You still count it.

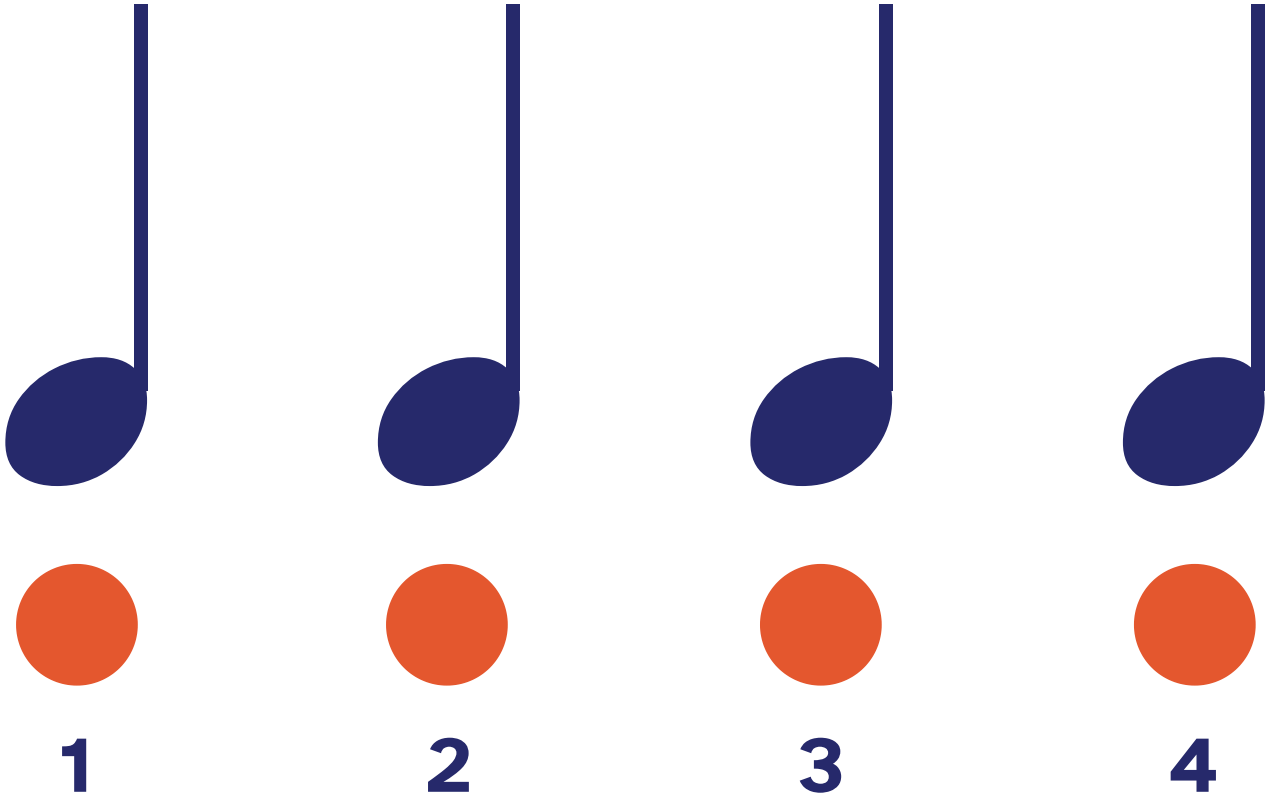
Try it

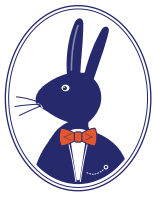
1 Clap three in a bar: STRONG, weak, weak. Then leave out one clap, but keep counting.

ROOM 6 · STEP 1 OF 3

Notes: crotchet and minim

SCAN TO LISTEN





This is a **crotchet**. It lasts **one beat**. One circle under a note means one beat.

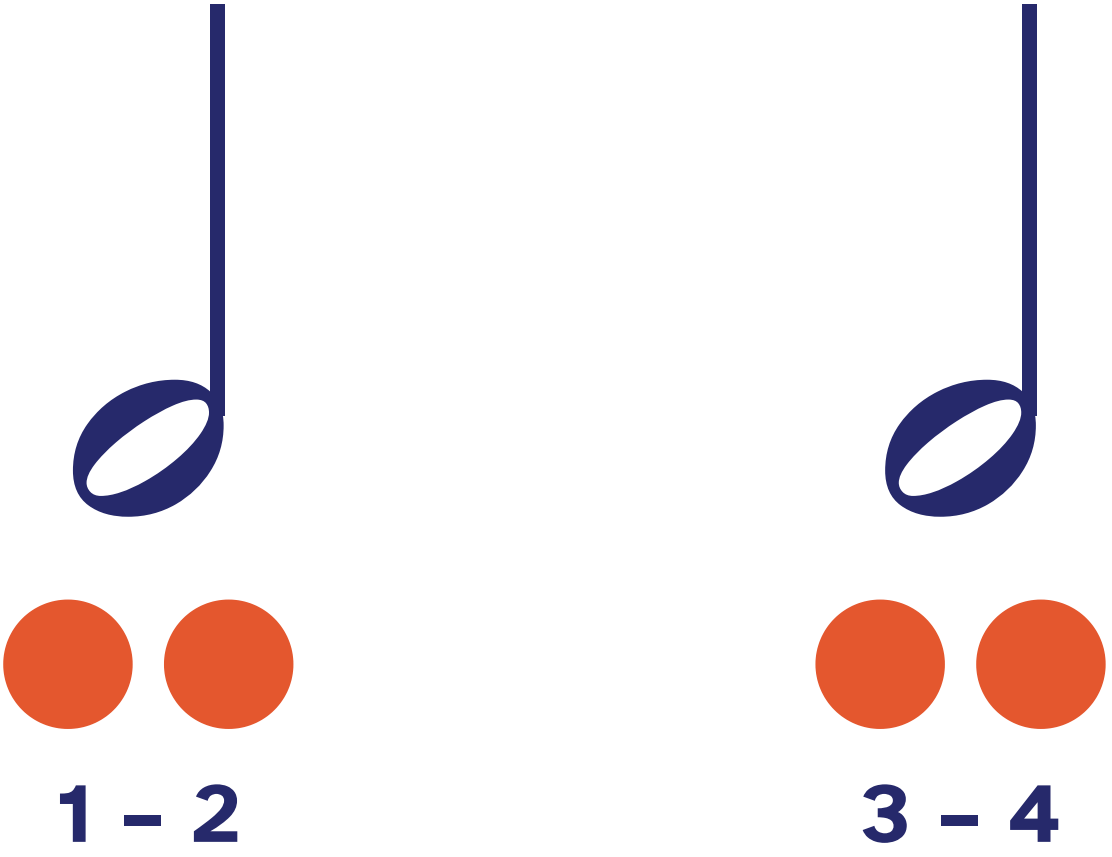
Four crotchets fill a bar of four: play, play, play, play.

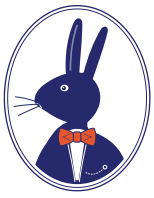
Try it at the piano

1 Play C four times, one for each beat, counting 1 2 3 4.

ROOM 6 · STEP 2 OF 3

Notes: crotchet and minim





This is a **minim**. Its head is empty, and it lasts **two beats**.

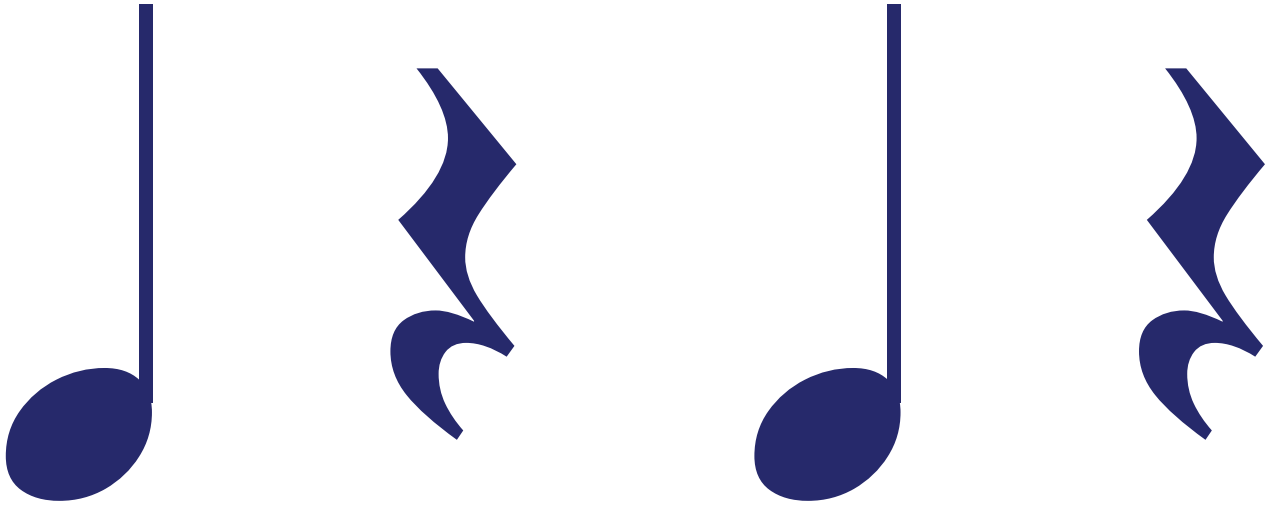
Play on the first beat and **hold** through the second.

Try it at the piano

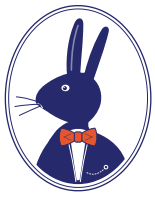
1. Play C as a minim: press on 1, hold through 2. Then again on 3, holding through 4.

ROOM 6 · STEP 3 OF 3

Notes: crotchet and minim



play shh play shh



Silence has signs too, called **rests**. A **crotchet rest** is one beat of silence.

You count a rest just like a note. You just do not play.

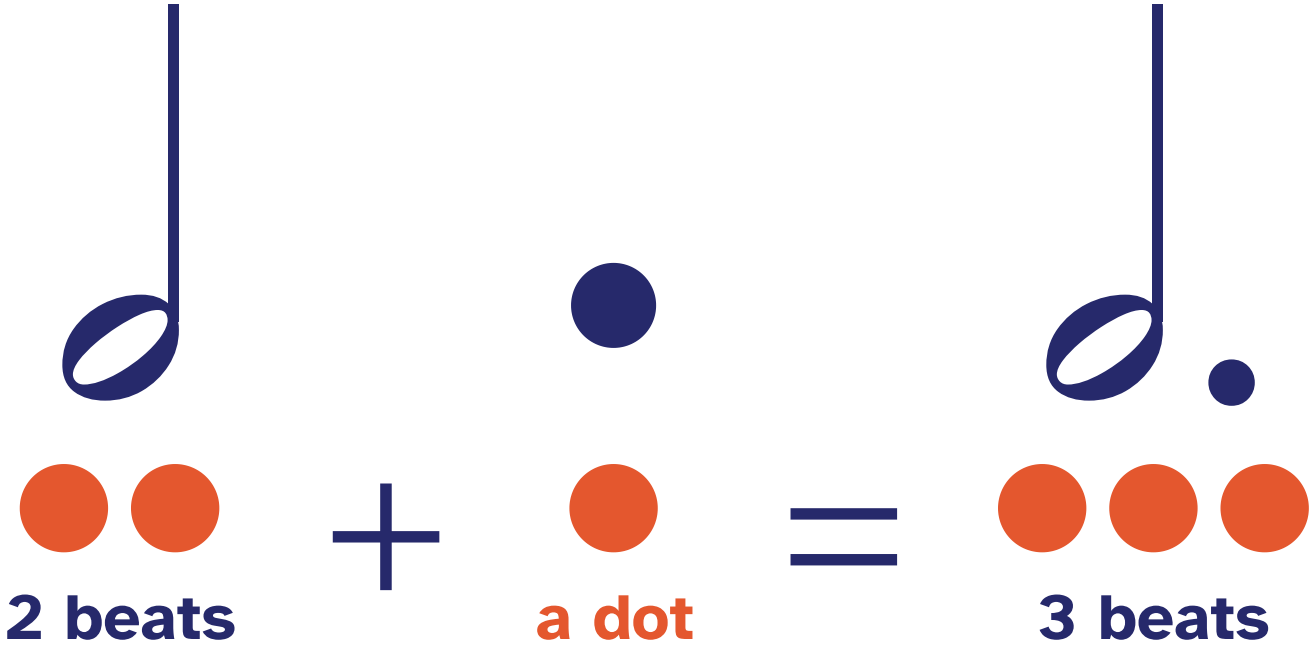
Try it at the piano

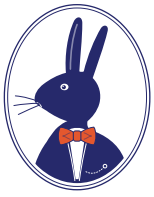
1. Play, shh, play, shh: C on beats 1 and 3, silence on 2 and 4. Keep counting.

ROOM 7 · STEP 1 OF 3

Notes: dotted minim and semibreve

SCAN TO LISTEN





A **dot** after a minim adds one more beat.

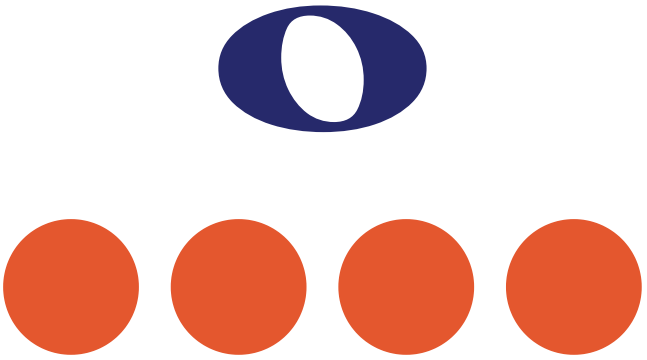
Two beats and one more: a **dotted minim** lasts **three beats**.

Try it at the piano

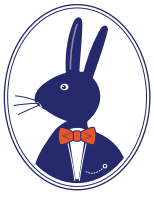
1 Play C and hold for 1 2 3. Play beat 1 a little stronger.

ROOM 7 · STEP 2 OF 3

Notes: dotted minim and semibreve



1 – 2 – 3 – 4



This is a **semibreve**: an empty head and no stem. It lasts **four beats**, a whole bar of four.

Press once, and listen until the sound has had all four beats.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C and hold for 1 2 3 4. Lift exactly when the next bar begins.

ROOM 7 · STEP 3 OF 3

Notes: dotted minim and semibreve

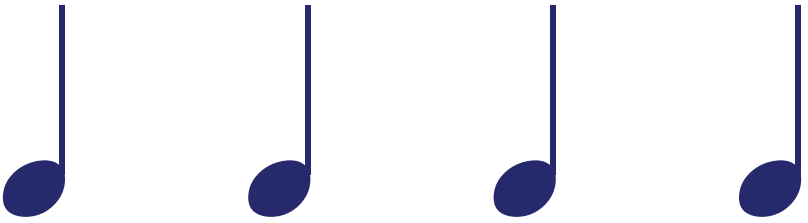
1 semibreve

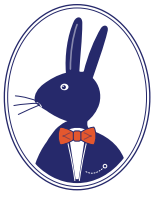


2 minims



4 crotchets





Now you know the family. Each note is **half** of the one above it.

One semibreve is as long as two minims, or four crotchets.

Try it at the piano

1. Play four crotchets on C. Then one semibreve, held for all four beats. The same length!

ROOM 8 · THE STORY

Loud and soft

SCAN TO LISTEN

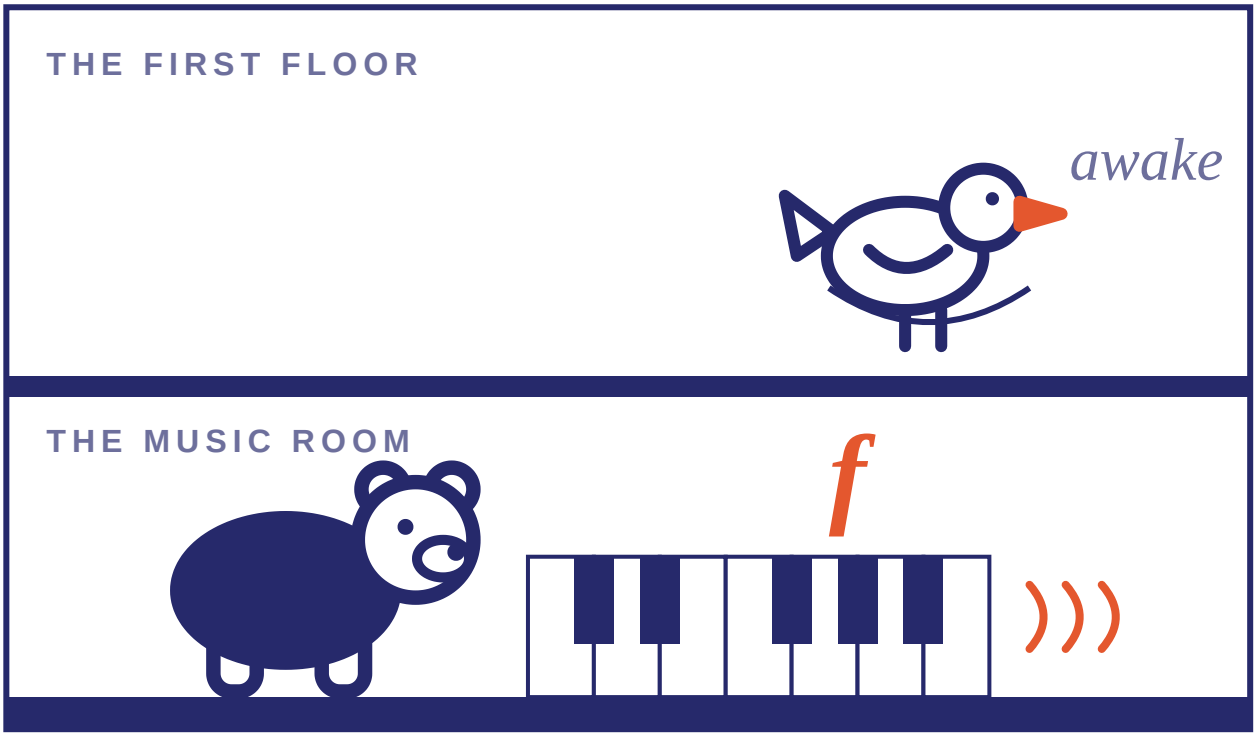
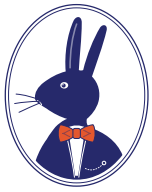


Plate VIII. Mr Bear at the piano, at full strength.



Mr **Bear** plays every note at **full strength**. On the floor above, Miss **Bird** has given up on sleep.

He is not wrong to play loudly. He has simply never been told that the piano can also **whisper**.

Try it at the piano

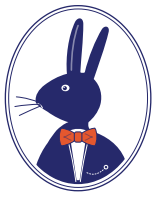
1 Play one C as Mr Bear would. Then one so quiet that the floor above would not notice.

ROOM 8 · STEP 1 OF 2

Loud and soft



p soft ***f*** loud



Music can be **soft** or **loud**. The signs are Italian: ***p*** for *piano*, soft, and ***f*** for *forte*, loud.

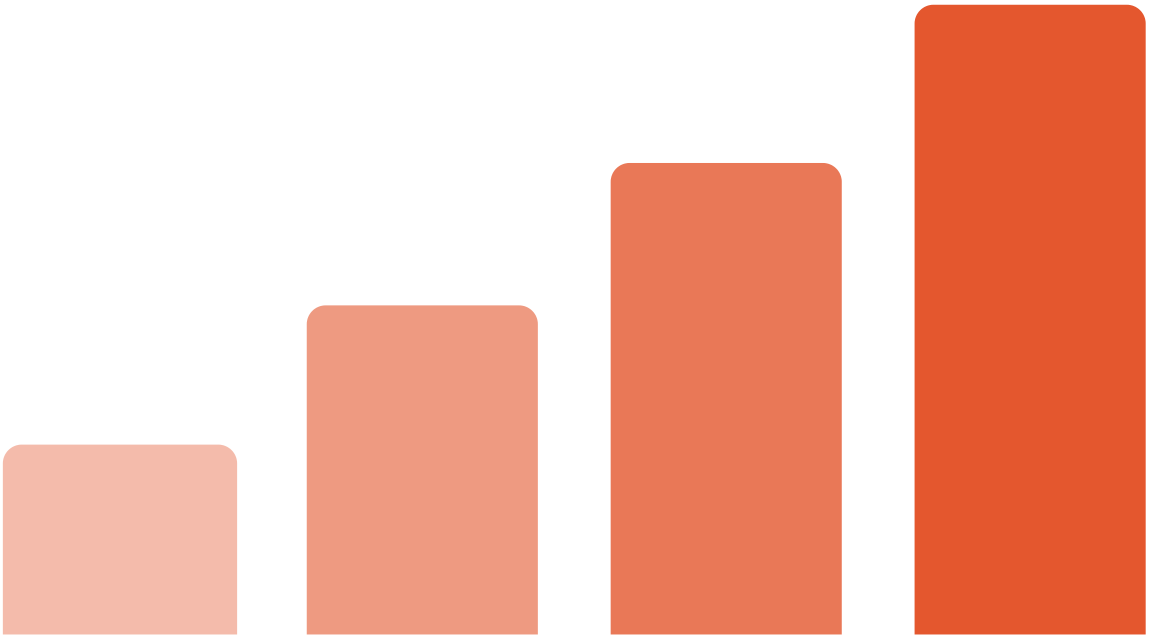
To play louder, let your arm feel heavy. Do not hit the key.

Try it at the piano

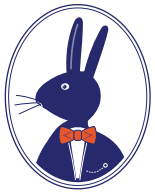
1. Play C softly, like a secret. Then play it loudly, like calling across a field. ○

ROOM 8 · STEP 2 OF 2

Loud and soft



p	***mp***	***mf***	***f***
soft	quite soft	quite loud	loud



Between soft and loud come two more signs. The ***m*** is for *mezzo*, which means **half** or **medium**: ***mp*** is quite soft, ***mf*** is quite loud.

Soft does not mean slow, and loud does not mean fast. The beat stays the same.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C four times: p, mp, mf, f. Four steps, the same speed. ○

ROOM 8 · HOW IT ENDED

Loud and soft

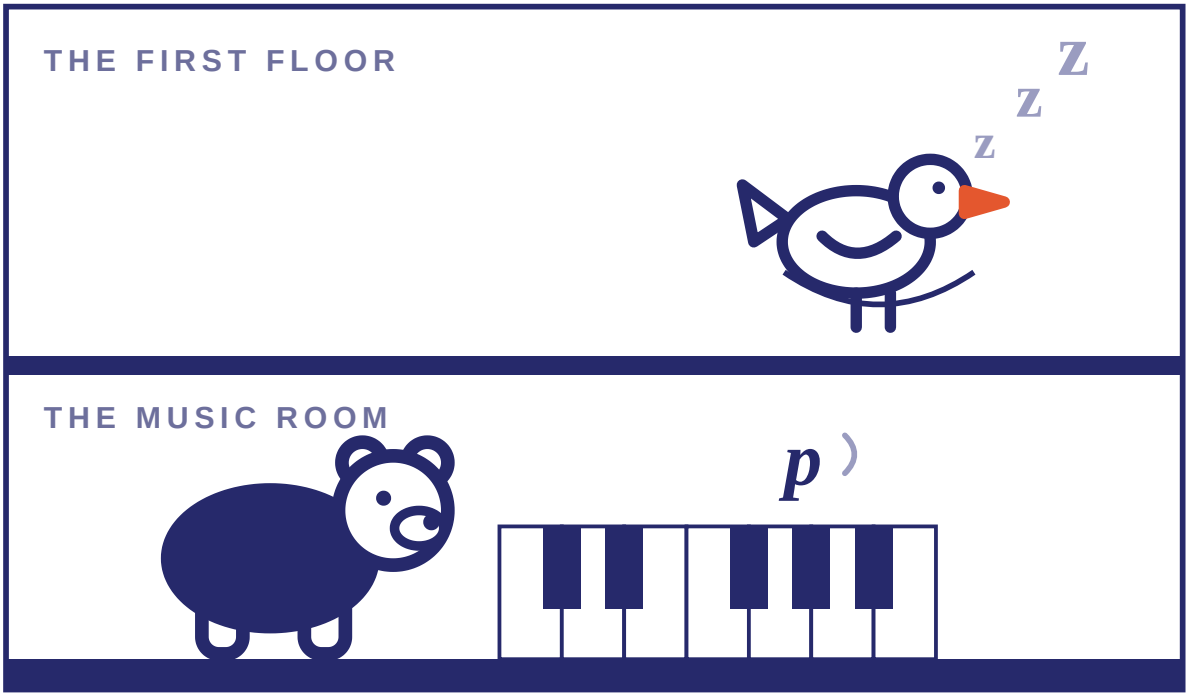
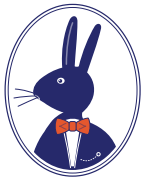


Plate VIII, continued. The same piano, a different hand.



Mr Bear now plays ***p*** after ten, and saves his ***f*** for the moments that need it. Loud means more when soft came first.

Haydn knew this. In his *Surprise* Symphony a quiet tune is suddenly broken by one loud chord. The story goes that he wrote it to wake up the audience.

Try it at the piano

1. Play a tune you know softly. Then play it again with just one loud note somewhere. Where does the surprise work best?

ROOM 9 · LISTEN

Ear training

SCAN TO PLAY

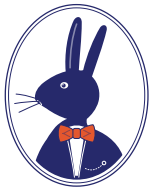
1 Low, middle or high?

2 Same clapping, or different?

3 Same tune, or different?

4 Which way did it go?

5 Find the note



Listen first, then play. Good ears make good fingers.

Five listening games are waiting in the app. Scan the code and play one each day.

Try it at the piano

1. Before you play a note, sing it. Then play it and listen: were you right?